

Plants for play

Children love to explore! Transform your garden into a jungle of secret hideouts and tunnels and add interesting plants to ensure they are never bored.

Weave narrow paths between tough shrubs, such as spotted laurel and or tall bamboo that tolerate wear and tear. Also consider a living plant feature, such as a tunnel or teepee made from willow—you can buy the “withies” (young stems) in early spring from specialist suppliers who will provide you with weaving instructions too. Plants that resemble animal features, such as hare’s-tail grass and the cute mouse plant, will keep children entertained, while easy-to-grow annuals help stimulate their interest in gardening and nature—sunflowers and marigolds are good choices.



PERENNIAL SMALL

Arisarum proboscideum

MOUSE PLANT This clump-forming perennial bears strange blooms that intrigue children. The maroon flowers have a white base and consist of a “hood,” which is drawn out into a mouse-like trap and conceals tiny flowers.

↑6in (15cm) ↔12in (30cm)

☀️ ☀️ Z7–9



SHRUB MEDIUM

Aucuba japonica

SPOTTED LAUREL This evergreen shrub has large, glossy green leaves decorated with small yellow spots. A tough resilient plant, it can be used to provide shelter and privacy near a play area. Plant males; berries of females cause stomach upset if ingested.

↑→6ft (2m)

☀️ ☀️ ☀️ ⚠️ Z7–10



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL LARGE

Amaranthus caudatus

LOVE-LIES-BLEEDING This tall bushy annual is fun to grow from seed and produces tall sturdy stems from which hang long, pendulous, tassel-like red flowers from summer to fall. Children can also cut them for indoor displays.

↑4ft (1.2m) ↔18in (45cm)

☀️ ☀️



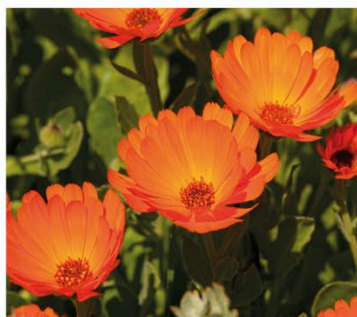
ANNUAL/BIENNIAL SMALL

Antirrhinum majus

SNAPDRAGON Lending color to summer pots and flowerbeds, this upright annual bears spikes of two-lipped crimson, red, pink, burgundy, white, and yellow flowers. When pressed at the base, the blooms open up to reveal a dragonlike mouth.

↑→18in (45cm)

☀️ ☀️



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL MEDIUM

Calendula officinalis

POT MARIGOLD Children will enjoy growing this bushy annual from seed. Its aromatic pale green leaves are joined by edible, daisy-like single or double flowers in shades of yellow and orange from late spring to fall.

↑→24in (60cm)

☀️ ☀️



SHRUB LARGE

Corylus avellana 'Contorta'

HARRY LAUDER'S WALKING STICK The twisted shoots of this deciduous shrub fascinate children, and give the garden a spooky look, when the green leaves fall in fall. Considered invasive in the Northwest and some parts of the Northeast.

↑15ft (5m) ↔15ft (5m)

☀️ ☀️ ☀️ Z4–8



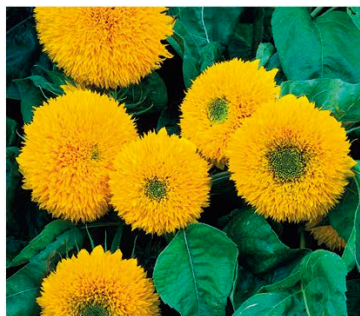
PERENNIAL SMALL

Fragaria vesca

ALPINE STRAWBERRY This type of strawberry produces small sweet berries all summer, which children love. Plant in pots or directly in the soil. It is easy to look after and is ideal for teaching children how to care for plants themselves.

↑12in (30cm) ↔indefinite

☀️ ☀️ ☀️ Z5–9 Ⓝ



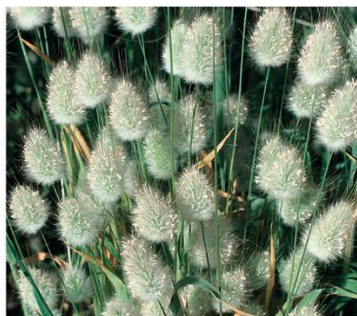
ANNUAL/BIENNIAL MEDIUM

Helianthus annuus

SUNFLOWER The edible seeds of this robust annual are easy for children to handle and sow. It bears classic daisy-like orange or yellow flowers throughout summer. Dwarf varieties include 'Teddy Bear' (above), with fluffy double blooms.

↑up to 3ft (1m) ↔24in (60cm)

☀️ ☀️ Ⓝ



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL SMALL

Lagurus ovatus

HARE'S-TAIL GRASS This clump-forming annual grass has green leaves and, in early summer, oval, furry white flower heads, which resemble soft rabbits' tails and last into fall. They also make beautiful indoor displays.

↑18in (45cm) ↔6in (15cm)

☀️ ☀️



CLIMBER LARGE

Luffa cylindrica

SMOOTH LOOFAH Grow your own loofah sponge from seed with this climbing annual. It has maplelike leaves and yellow flowers followed by elongated fruits that produce loofahs when dried. It needs a sheltered, sunny site to thrive.

↑15ft (5m)

☀️ ☀️